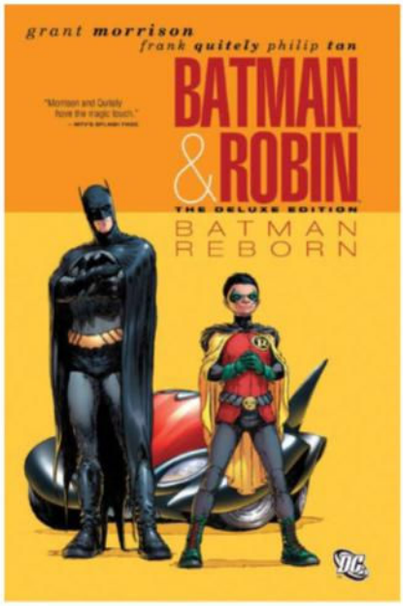


GRANT MORRISON

HE'S NOT QUITTING SUPERHEROES – SAYING BYE TO BATMAN AND SO LONG TO SUPERMAN – BUT HE IS TAKING A BREATHER. WHILE PROJECTS BREW IN THE MIND OF GRANT MORRISON, WE TALK TO THE LEGENDARY WRITER ABOUT WINDING DOWN BATMAN INC AND ACTION COMICS, HIS SERIES HAPPY! AND WHAT COMES NEXT...

When Grant Morrison announced that he was finishing his run on both Action Comics and Batman Incorporated in 2012 and taking a break from the grind of monthly comics, the fan communities went into overdrive. The headlines hit the ground in a storm of over-excited punctuation – Grant Morrison Quits DC! Grant Morrison Finished With Superheroes! Grant Morrison Leaving Comics! – none of which were true.

Morrison is used to his quotes being taken out of context – and in some cases taken out of any hint of reality – but looking beyond the headlines revealed the true story: the writer was moving out of ongoing superhero titles and concentrating on a number of new projects, including superheroes, both within DC and with other publishers, including Image. We caught up with Morrison in a bar in Edinburgh to chat about leaving Clark and Bruce behind and what is yet to come, while noting that the location, The Voodoo Rooms bar, was perhaps a rather apt venue in which to meet the enigmatic writer.

With DC's New 52, the continuity of the DC timeline has been completely updated, squashing decades into a five-year span to create a more contemporary feel. This has, however, resulted in some characters disappearing, which proved controversial with fans, as well as some confusion over which stories in the past are still considered canon. As someone who had previously woven together the entire Batman mythos into one continuous whole, how did Morrison cope with writing *Batman Incorporated* in the new DC Universe?

"I just thought that ultimately it will all eventually stretch out again," Morrison explains to us. "I thought it was much more inclusive to have all of Batman's history in the story and to even accommodate the fact that his history has kind of changed slightly again, because it will change again. So I just wanted to keep with what I had, and there were some things we had to change – like suddenly Stephanie Brown didn't exist, and Cassandra Cain doesn't exist, and they'll get reintroduced in some way potentially – but I had this really great scene in *Batman Incorporated* #4 with these two characters in it, and I liked them. I thought there were things we could do with it – I liked the fact it was two women there."

The loss of Stephanie Brown, replaced as Batgirl by her original predecessor, Barbara Gordon, has attracted a particularly dramatic reaction from fans. *Batman Incorporated* #3 featured a page where a blonde woman is kidnapped and brainwashed, and subsequently reappears as a redhead with dangerous intent – a play, perhaps, on the change from blonde to red-headed Batgirl?

"No, it wasn't any commentary; sometimes these things just happen spontaneously," Morrison laughs. "So yes, it was commentary if you saw commentary! But no, she's just gone. I liked that character. Not that there's much there, honestly, but there's something."

One character that has remained prominent in Batman's life is his son, Damian, a character that was reintroduced by Morrison six years ago and had largely remained in his care until the New 52 launch. Still a favourite with the fans, Damian currently appears in a number of Bat-titles, including *Batman Incorporated*. Is Morrison kept abreast of what the character is doing in his other adventures?

"I read [the comics] when they come out, but I don't usually get sent anything," he frowns. "I send in these detailed plot synopses at the start of everything... I never see anybody's plot synopses!"

The thought occurs that perhaps others are shown Morrison's outlines rather than the other way around.

"George Perez didn't seem to get mine!" Morrison laughs. "But yeah, I've no idea what's happening, I just... I don't bother about that stuff. I remember at the start of this they said they wanted to tie in with [*Batman* writer] Scott Snyder and [*Detective Comics* writer] Pete Tomasi, and you've got to tell them if you want to do this – I said, 'No, those guys have got their own big stories to tell, I'm sure we'll make it work.' That's why people hate me! But it's not important; I'd rather see what they've got to say, even if I don't necessarily agree with it."

It's clear that Morrison has something particular in mind. "Damian should not have a dog; Damian had a cat," he states flatly. "I'm really upset that they gave him a dog, because we've already seen him growing up in the future with a cat, and I had this plan to introduce this kitten, but he's brought a dog into it..."

The writer tails off glumly, before we remember the arrival of Bat-Cow earlier in the series. "Oh, he's got a cow!" Morrison grins. "So maybe... I think he should have a whole menagerie of bat-animals."

Morrison is finishing Batman Incorporated with Issue 12, and has extended his Action Comics run to Issue 17, long after his initially planned first six-issue run. While the *Superman* title chronicles the adventures of Superman in the present day, *Action Comics* is set five years in the past, and focuses on a young Clark Kent who has not yet got to grip with his powers. This is the Superman who can leap over buildings, rather than the indestructible god he becomes.

"I was only going to do the first six," he says, "and then [artist] Rags Morales needed a couple of issues off, so I had this insert

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